THE LITTLE BOOK OF HYGGE

(pronounced **HOO-GA**)

DANISH SECRETS TO HAPPY LIVING

MEIK WIKING

CEO of the Happiness
Research Institute, Copenhagen

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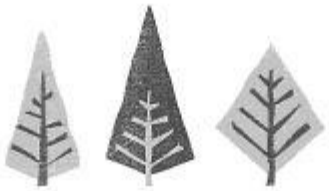
Danish Secrets to Happy Living



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WILLIAM MORROW
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Originally published in the United Kingdom in 2016 by Penguin Random House UK.

Lyrics on page 178 from "The Happy Day of Svante" by Benny Andersen are from Hojskolesangbogen, translated by Kurt Hansen

Designed by Hampton Associates

Library of Congress Cataloging-in-Publication Data has been applied for.

ISBN 978-0-06-265880-7

17 18 19 20 21 RRD 10 9 8 7 6 5 4 3 2 1

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INTRODUCTION

Hooga? Hhyooguh? *Heurgh? It is not important how you choose to pronounce or even spell* hygge. *To paraphrase one of the greatest philosophers of our time—Winnie-the-Pooh—when asked how to spell a certain emotion, "You don't spell it, you feel it."*

However, spelling and pronouncing *hygge* is the easy part. Explaining exactly what it is, that's the tricky part. Hygge has been called everything from "the art of creating intimacy," "coziness of the soul," and "the absence of annoyance," to "taking pleasure from the presence of soothing things," "cozy togetherness," and my personal favorite, "cocoa by candlelight".

Hygge is about an atmosphere and an experience, rather than about things. It is about being with the people we love. A feeling of home. A feeling that we are safe, that we are shielded from the world and allow ourselves to let our guard down. You may be having an endless conversation about the small or big things in life—or just be comfortable in each other's silent company—or simply just be by yourself enjoying a cup of tea.

One December just before Christmas, I was spending the weekend with some friends at an old cabin. The shortest day of the year was brightened by the blanket of snow covering the surrounding landscape. When the sun set, around four in the afternoon, we would not see it again for seventeen hours, and we headed inside to get the fire going.

We were all tired after hiking and were half asleep, sitting in a semicircle around the fireplace in the cabin, wearing big sweaters and woolen socks. The only sounds you could hear were the stew boiling, the sparks from the fireplace, and someone having a sip of mulled wine. Then one of my friends broke the silence.

"Could this be any more hygge?" he asked rhetorically.

"Yes," one of the women said after a moment. "If there was a storm raging outside."

We all nodded.

THE KEY TO HAPPINESS?

I have the best job in the world. I study what makes people happy. At the Happiness Research Institute, which is an independent think tank focusing on well-being, happiness, and quality of life, we explore the causes and effects of human happiness and work toward improving the quality of life of citizens across the world.

We are based in Denmark, and yes, we do have lit candles at the office Monday to Friday, and yes, our office was partly chosen because of the hygge factor. No fireplace, though. Yet. But we were also founded and are based in Denmark because the country consistently ranks among the happiest nations in the world. Denmark is by no means a perfect utopia, and the country faces challenges and issues like any other country, but I do believe Denmark can be a source of inspiration for how countries can increase the quality of life of their citizens.

Denmark's position as one of the happiest countries in the world has created a lot of media interest. On a weekly basis, I am asked questions like "Why are the Danes so happy?" and "What can we learn from the Danes when it comes to happiness?" from journalists from *The New York Times*, the BBC, *The Guardian*, the *China Daily*, and *The Washington Post*, among others. In addition, delegations of mayors, researchers, and policy makers from all corners of the earth frequently visit the Happiness Research Institute in pursuit of . . . well . . . happiness—or at least in pursuit of the reasons for the high levels of happiness, well-being, and quality of life people enjoy in

Denmark. To many, it is quite the mystery, as besides the horrific weather, Danes are also subject to some of the highest tax rates in the world.

Interestingly, there is wide support for the welfare state. The support stems from an awareness of the fact that the welfare model turns our collective wealth into well-being. We are not paying taxes, we are investing in our society. We are purchasing quality of life. The key to understanding the high levels of well-being in Denmark is the welfare model's ability to reduce risk, uncertainty, and anxiety among its citizens and to prevent extreme unhappiness.

However, recently, I have also come to realize that there might be an overlooked ingredient in the Danish recipe for happiness—hygge. The word *hygge* originates from a Norwegian word meaning "well-being". For almost five hundred years, Denmark and Norway were one kingdom, until Denmark lost Norway in 1814. *Hygge* appeared in written Danish for the first time in the early 1800s, and the link between hygge and well-being or happiness may be no coincidence.

Danes are the happiest people in Europe according to the European Social Survey, but they are also the ones who meet most often with their friends and family and feel the calmest and most peaceful. Therefore, it is with good reason that we see a growing interest in hygge. Journalists are touring Denmark searching for hygge; in the UK, a college is now teaching Danish hygge; and around the world, hygge bakeries, shops, and cafés are popping up. But how do you create hygge? How are hygge and happiness linked? And what is hygge exactly? Those are some of the questions this book seeks to answer.

CHAPTER ONE

LIGHT

INSTANT HYGGE: CANDLES

No recipe for hygge is complete without candles. When Danes are asked what they most associate with hygge, an overwhelming 85 percent will mention candles.

The word for "spoilsport" in Danish is *lyseslukker*, which means "the one who puts out the candles", and this is no coincidence. There is no faster way to get to hygge than to light a few candles or, as they are called in Danish, *levende lys*, or living lights. The American ambassador to Denmark, Rufus Gifford, said of the Danes' love affair with candles: "I mean, it is not just in the living room. It is everywhere. In your classrooms, in your boardrooms. As an American, you think, 'Fire hazard!—how can you possibly have an open flame in your classroom?' It is kind of an emotional happiness, an emotional coziness."

The American ambassador is onto something. According to the European Candle Association, Denmark burns more candles per head than anywhere in Europe. Each Dane burns around thirteen pounds of candle wax each year. To put this in context, each Dane consumes around six and a half pounds of bacon per year (yes, bacon consumption per capita is a standard metric in Denmark). The candle consumption is a European record. In fact, Denmark burns almost twice as much candle wax as the runner-up, Austria, with a little under seven pounds per year. However, scented candles are not a big thing. In fact, Asp-Holmblad, Denmark's oldest producer of candles, doesn't even include scented candles in their product range. Scented candles are considered artificial, and Danes prefer natural and organic products. In fact, Danes rank towards the top of the list in Europe when it comes to buying organic.

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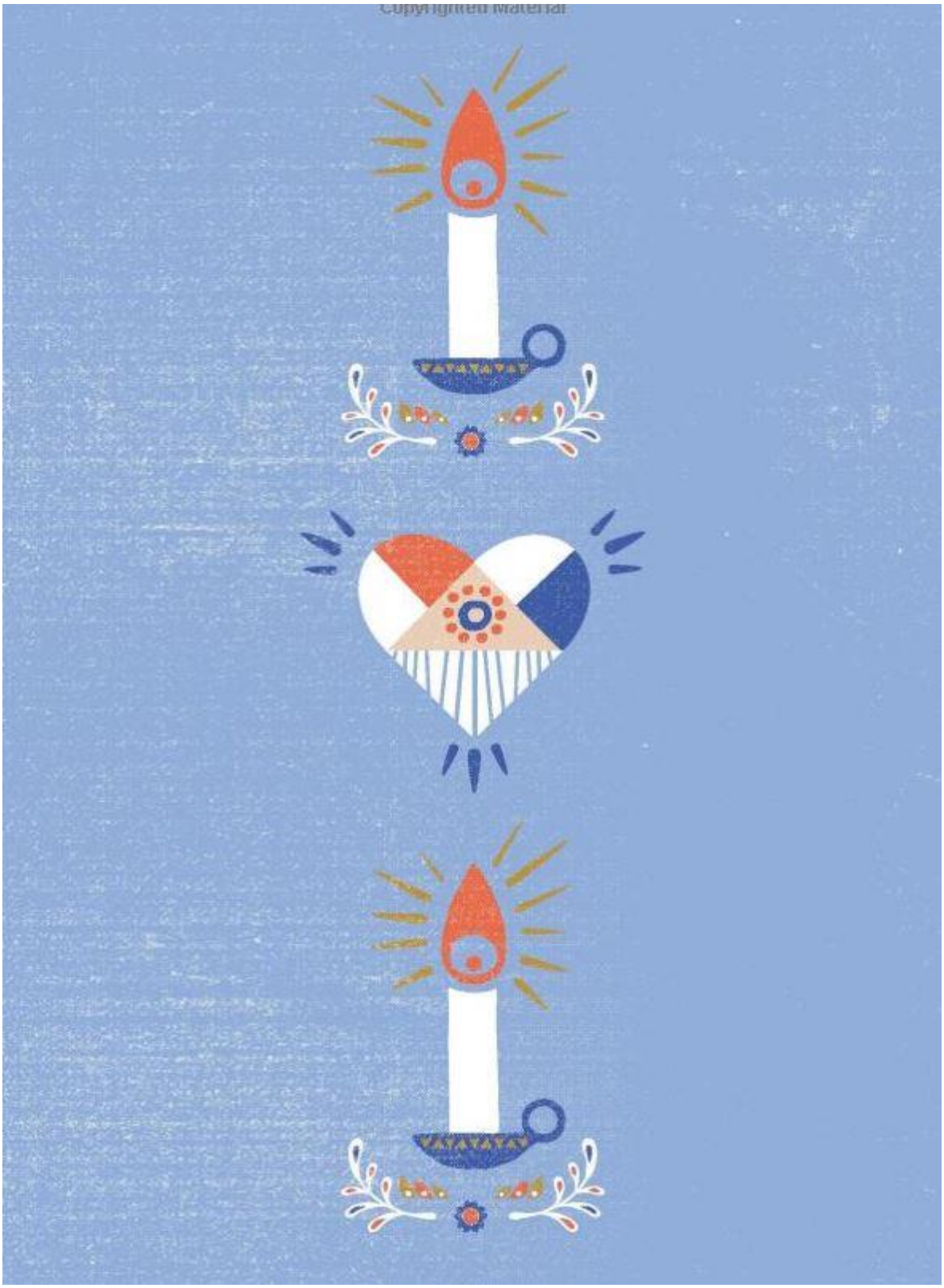
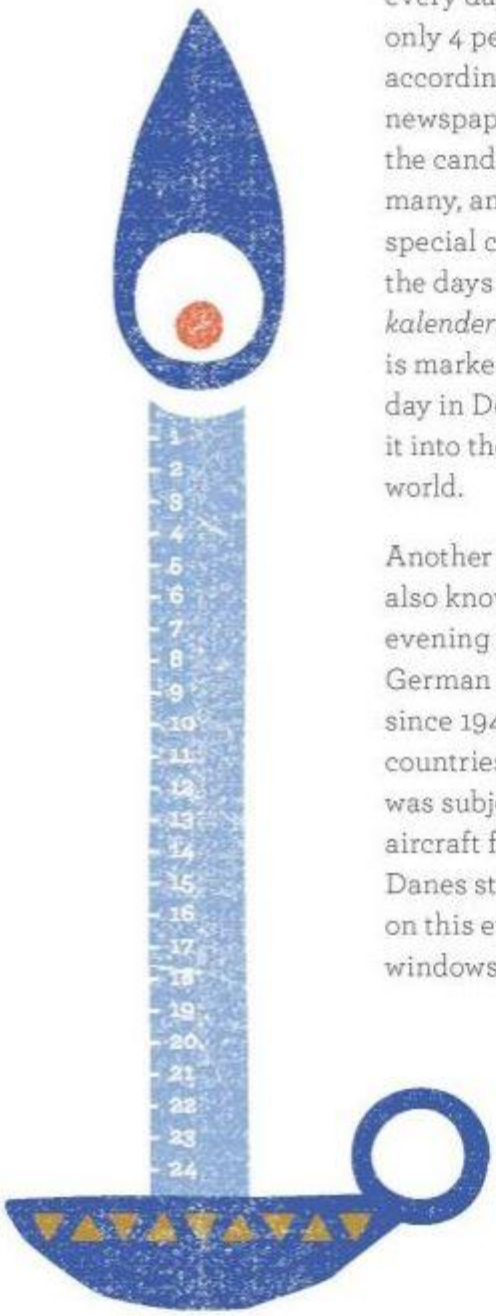




More than half of Danes light candles almost every day during autumn and winter, and only 4 percent say they never light candles, according to a survey by one of the major newspapers in Denmark. During December, the candle consumption soars to thrice as many, and this is also the time to witness the special candle that is to be burned only in the days leading up to Christmas, namely the *kalenderlys*—the advent candle. This candle is marked with twenty-four lines, one for each day in December before Christmas, turning it into the slowest countdown clock in the world.

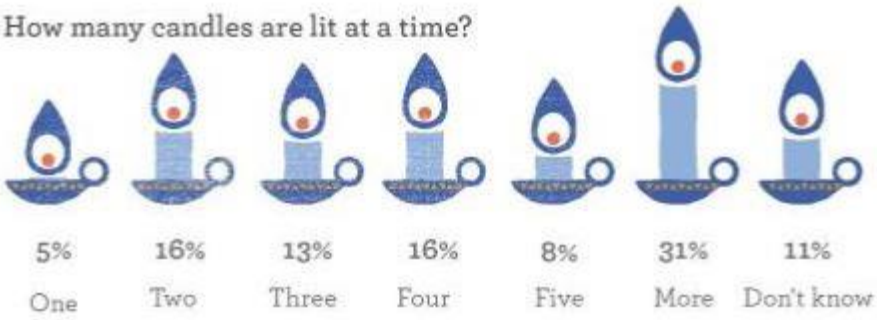
Another special candle occasion is May 4, also known as *lysfest*, or light party. On this evening in 1945, the BBC broadcast that the German forces who had occupied Denmark since 1940 had surrendered. As in many countries during World War II, Denmark was subject to blackouts to prevent enemy aircraft from navigating by city lights. Today, Danes still celebrate the return of the light on this evening by putting candles in their windows.

Hyggelige as the Danes may be, there is one serious drawback to being crazy about candles: the soot. Studies show that lighting just one candle fills the air with more microparticles than traffic in a busy street.

A study undertaken by the Danish Building Research Institute showed that candles shed more particles indoors than either cigarettes or cooking. Despite Denmark being a highly regulated country, we have yet to see warning labels on candles. Nobody messes with the hygge fanatics. There is now a growing awareness among Danes of the importance of airing out a room after burning candles. Nevertheless, despite the health implications, Danes continue to consume candles in obscene quantities.

How often do Danes light candles?

How many candles are lit at a time?



LAMPS

Lighting is not just about candles. Danes are obsessed by lighting in general. I once spent two hours walking around Rome with my girlfriend at the time to find a restaurant that had hyggelig *lighting.*

Danes select lamps carefully and place them strategically to create soothing pools of light. It is an art form, a science, and an industry. Some of the most beautifully designed lamps in the world come from the golden age of Danish design—for example, the lamps of Poul Henningsen, Arne Jacobsen, and Verner Panton. Visit a student on a shoestring budget and you may still encounter a $1,300 Verner Panton lamp in the corner of her hundred-square-foot flat.

The rule of thumb is: the lower the temperature of the light, the more hygge. A camera flash is around 5,500 Kelvin (K), fluorescent tubes are 5,000K, incandescent lamps 3,000K, while sunsets and wood and candle flames are about 1,800K. That is your hygge sweet spot.

The closest you will ever come to seeing vampires burned by daylight is by inviting a group of Danes for a hygge dinner and then placing them under a 5,000K fluorescent light tube. At first they will squint, trying to examine the torture device you have placed in the ceiling. Then, as dinner begins, observe how they move uncomfortably around in their chairs, compulsively scratching and trying to suppress twitches.

The obsession with lighting comes from the lack of contact with it in the natural world from October to March. During this time, the only resource Denmark has in abundance is darkness. Summers in Denmark are beautiful. When the first rays of light reach the country, Danes awaken from their hibernation and fall over themselves to find spots in the sun. I love summer in Denmark. It is my favorite time of the year. And if it wasn't bad enough that winters are dark and cold and summers are short, Denmark also has 179 days of rain per year. *Game of Thrones* fans, think of the city of Winterfell.

That is why hygge has been refined to the level it has, and why it is seen as part of the national identity and culture in Denmark. Hygge is the antidote to the cold winter, the rainy days, and the duvet of darkness. So while you can have hygge all year round, it is during winter that it becomes not only a necessity but a survival strategy. That is why Danes have a reputation of being hygge fundamentalists and talk about it . . . a lot.

My favorite spot in my apartment in Copenhagen is the windowsill in the kitchen-dining area. It is wide enough to sit comfortably in and I've added pillows and blankets to make it a real *hyggekrog* (see the hygge dictionary on page 26). The radiator underneath the windowsill makes it the perfect place to enjoy a cup of tea on a cold winter night. But what I like about it most is the warm amber glow issuing from every apartment across the courtyard. It's a constantly changing mosaic of radiance as people leave and return home. In part, I owe this view to Poul Henningsen. Inevitably, a well-lit room in Denmark is likely to hold a lamp by the architect and designer all Danes know simply as PH.

He was to light fixtures what Edison was to the lightbulb. PH was, like most Danes today, obsessed with light. Some call him the world's first lighting architect, as he devoted his career to

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exploring the importance of light for our well-being, aiming to develop a lamp that could spread light without subjecting people to a direct glare.

Poul Henningsen was born in 1894 and did not grow up with electric light but in the soft glow of petroleum lamps. These were his source of inspiration. His designs shape and refine the power of the electric light yet maintain the softness of the light of a petroleum lamp.

> *It doesn't cost money to light a room correctly—but it does require culture. From the age of eighteen, when I began to experiment with light, I have been searching for harmony in lighting. Human beings are like children. As soon as they get new toys, they throw away their culture and the orgy starts. The electric light gave the possibility of wallowing in light.*
>
> *When, in the evening, from the top of a tram car, you look into all the homes on the first floor, you shudder at how dismal people's homes are. Furniture, style, carpets—everything in the home is unimportant, compared to the positioning of the lighting.*
>
> **Poul Henningsen** *(1894-1967), "On Light"*

THREE ICONIC DANISH LAMPS

1 THE PH LAMP

After a decade of experiments with lamps and lighting in his attic, Henningsen presented the first PH lamp in 1925. It gave a softer and more diffused light by using a series of layered shades to disperse the light yet conceal the lightbulb. In addition, to bring the harsh white light toward the red end of the spectrum, PH gave the inner side of one element of the shade a red colour. His biggest success was PH5, which has metal shades and was launched in 1958, but PH lamps have now been produced in over a thousand different designs. Many of these are not in production anymore, and the rarest lamps can go for more than $25,000 at auction.

2 LE KLINT

In 1943, the Klint family started producing lampshades with folding pleats, but in fact they had been designed four decades earlier by Peder Vilhelm Jensen-Klint, a Danish architect, for his own use, as he had designed a petroleum lamp and needed a shade. It became a family business, applying the skills in design, innovation, and business of the sons and daughters of Klint.

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ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

I would like to thank the researchers at the Happiness Research Institute—Johan, Felicia, Michael, and Kjartan—for their help with this book. Without them, work would not be half as hyggeligt.

La Glace, June 2016

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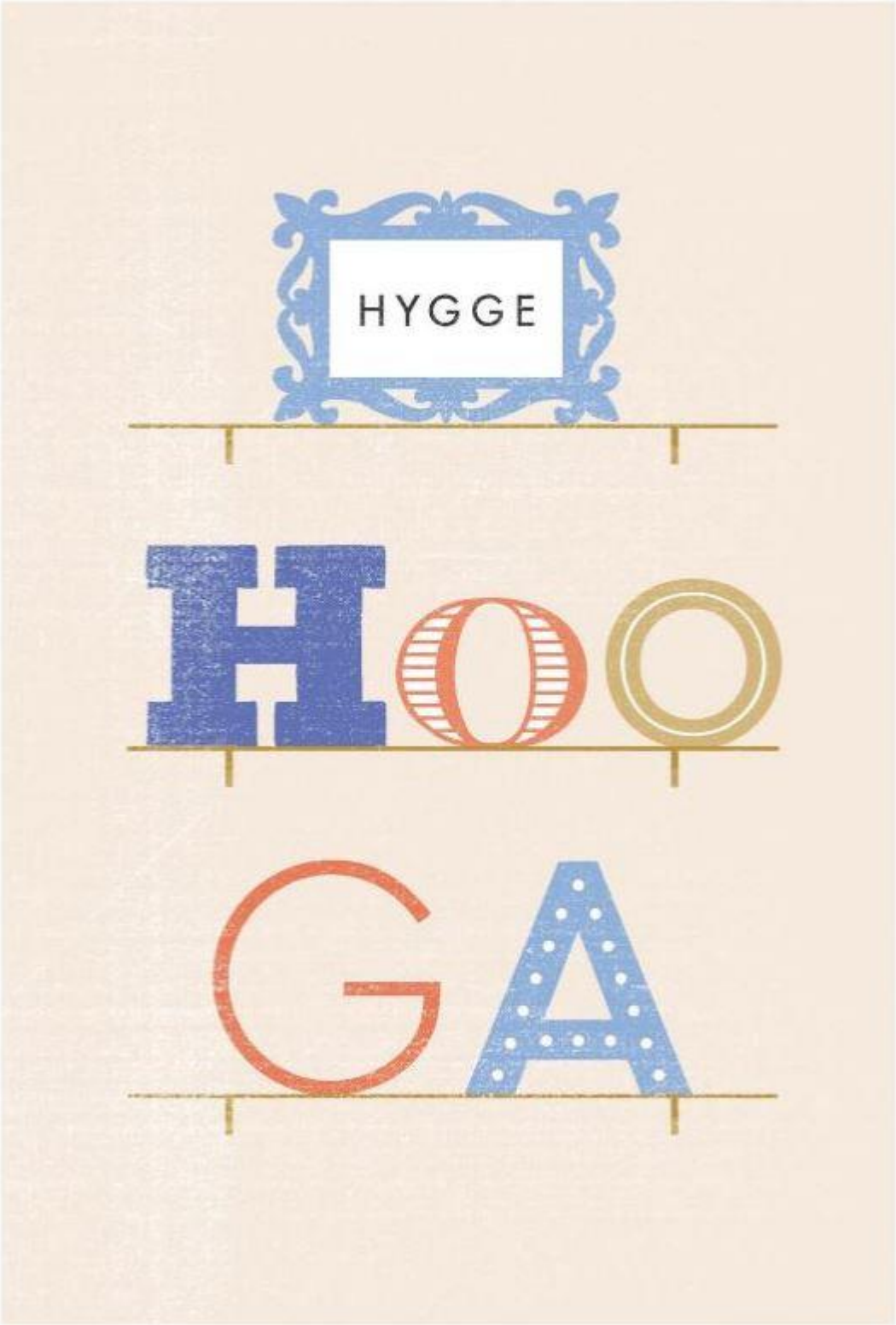
Meik Wiking is CEO of the Happiness Research Institute, research associate for Denmark at the World Database of Happiness, and founding member of the Latin American Network for Wellbeing and Quality of Life Policies. He and his research have been featured in more than five hundred media outlets, including *The Washington Post*, BBC, *Huffington Post*, the *Times* (London), *The Guardian*, CBS, Monocle, the *Atlantic*, and PBS News Hour. He has spoken at TEDx, and his books have been translated into more than fifteen languages. He lives in Copenhagen, Denmark.


HYGGE
HOOGA

NEW YORK TIMES BESTSELLER

Get consciously cozy.

The Danes are famously the happiest people in the world, and *hygge* is a cornerstone of their way of life. *Hygge* (pronounced *Hoo-ga*) loosely translates as a sense of comfort, togetherness, and well-being. You know *hygge* when you feel it. It is when you are cuddled up on a sofa with a loved one, or sharing comfort food with your closest friends. It is those crisp blue mornings when the light through your window is just right. It is about gratitude and savoring the simple pleasures in life. In short, it is the pursuit of everyday happiness.

Who better than **MEIK WIKING** to be your guide to all things *hygge*? Meik is the CEO of the Happiness Research Institute in Copenhagen and has spent years studying the magic of Danish life and what makes people happy. From bringing out the candles and spending time with your tribe to giving yourself a break from the demands of healthy living (cake is most definitely *hygge*), Meik's beautiful, inspiring book will help you to be more *hygge*.

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ISBN 978-0-06-265880-7

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